

Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 19

Time allowed: 1 hour 50 minutes

Total marks for Sections B and C: 45

Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

Text 3: An elderly woman attends her granddaughter's wedding in the country to which her family migrated decades ago.

1

The hall smelt of flowers I could not name. They were tall and pale and rather too clever, arranged in glass towers along the centre of each table, and they reminded me of nothing I had ever grown in my own small garden. I sat where my daughter had placed me, near the front, with a cushion behind my back and a glass of water within reach. Around me, two hundred people were standing for a photograph. I stayed seated. My knees, at eighty-three, no longer rise for occasions.

2

My granddaughter looked, from a distance, like a stranger. The dress was beautiful — long and white and stitched with something that caught the light — but it was not the kind of dress that any of my sisters had worn, and her hair was pinned in a style I did not recognise. Yet when she turned her face towards the camera, I saw, in the angle of her jaw, my own mother's jaw; and in the soft hesitation of her smile, my late husband's, who had crossed the ocean with me forty-seven years ago and lived to see this country become a kind of home.

3

The food, when it came, was a procession of small white plates, each one carrying a single, careful thing: a folded leaf, a circle of fish, a clear soup in which one green herb floated like a thought. I ate slowly, and a little of each. My daughter, watching me, leaned across and whispered that she had asked the kitchen to keep something soft and warm aside for me, in case I was still hungry afterwards. I patted her hand. I was not hungry. I was somewhere else.

4

The speeches began. A young man I had never met stood up and told a long story about my granddaughter that drew great waves of laughter from the room. I caught perhaps one word in five. My English, even after all these years, prefers slowness; this young man spoke quickly, and the microphone gave his voice a

metallic edge that my ears, which are not what they were, did not care for. I smiled when others smiled. I clapped when others clapped. Inside, I was watching, with a quiet curiosity, the faces of people who had grown up belonging to this place.

5

Then, between courses, my granddaughter came and sat beside me. She had lifted her long skirts in one careful hand, and she lowered herself into the empty chair on my left with the slight breathlessness of a girl who has been on her feet for hours. For a moment she said nothing. She only reached for my hand, and held it, and her hand was warm and a little damp through her glove. “Grandma,” she said at last, in the language of my childhood — a language she speaks haltingly, like someone who learned it from a grandmother and not from a country — “tell me a story. Anything. While I sit here.”

6

I had not been asked for a story in a long time. I closed my eyes for a moment, and I told her about the morning her grandfather and I left our village, in a truck that had no roof, with two suitcases and a tin of dried fish that her great-aunt had pressed into my hands at the gate. I told her how the road dust had clung to our wedding clothes, because we had nothing else clean to wear. I told her how, on the boat, I had been seasick for nine days and her grandfather had brought me cold water in a cup and sung to me very softly, in a voice that had no tune at all. I did not tell her everything. Some things one keeps.

7

My granddaughter listened without moving. Once, she squeezed my hand so hard that I felt the bones inside it. When I had finished, she did not speak. She lifted my old hand and pressed it, briefly, against her cheek — against the powder and the perfume, against the day that was hers and not mine — and then she got up, because somewhere a band had started playing, and her new husband was looking for her across the room.

8

I watched her go. The flowers were still too tall and the music was still too loud, and I still did not know the names of half the dishes on the table. But I sat very straight in my chair, and I thought: I crossed an ocean for this. I crossed an ocean so that a girl in a white dress, in a hall I cannot understand, could lean down to an old woman she loves, and ask, in a language she barely speaks, for a story.

From Paragraph 1

1. The narrator says the flowers were “tall and pale and rather too clever.” Explain, in your own words, what this phrase tells us about her attitude towards the decorations. [2]

2. The narrator writes, “My knees, at eighty-three, no longer rise for occasions.” What does this sentence suggest about the narrator? Give **two** points. [2]

From Paragraph 2

3. The narrator says her granddaughter looked “like a stranger” from a distance. What changes her perception, and what does this change tell us about how she sees her family? [2]

From Paragraph 3

4. The writer describes the food as “a procession of small white plates.” Explain how this image suggests the food is **unfamiliar** to the narrator. [2]

5. The narrator says, “I was not hungry. I was somewhere else.” What does the phrase **somewhere else** suggest about her state of mind during the meal? [1]

From Paragraph 4

6. In Paragraph 4, the narrator describes her experience of the speeches.

- (a) Give **one** reason why she has difficulty following them. [1]
- (b) Why does she “smile when others smiled” and “clap when others clapped”? [1]

From Paragraph 5

7. The narrator says her granddaughter speaks the language of her childhood “haltingly, like someone who learned it from a grandmother and not from a country.” Explain what this comparison suggests about how the granddaughter learned the language. [2]

From Paragraph 6

8. The narrator says, “I did not tell her everything. Some things one keeps.” What does this suggest about the narrator’s character? [2]

9. The narrator describes her husband’s singing as having “no tune at all.” What does this detail reveal about her memory of him? [2]

From Paragraph 7

10. The narrator describes her granddaughter pressing her hand “against the powder and the perfume, against the day that was hers and not mine.” Explain the contrast the writer creates here, and what it suggests about the narrator’s feelings. [2]

From Paragraph 8

11. What is the **tone** of the final paragraph of the text? [1]

Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]

Text 4: A feature article on why so many adults stop reading novels as they grow older.

1

At some point in their thirties or forties, a great many otherwise literate adults quietly stop reading novels. They do not announce this. They do not give away their bookshelves. They simply notice, one evening, that the paperback they began six months ago is still bookmarked on page forty-three, and that the bookmark has begun to gather dust. According to the United Kingdom's National Literacy Trust, the proportion of adults who read fiction "for pleasure" in their leisure time has fallen by more than ten percentage points in the past decade. In the United States, a 2022 Pew survey found that almost a quarter of adults had not finished a single novel in the previous year. The decline is gentle, ordinary, and almost entirely unnoticed.

2

The most obvious explanation is the screen. The average adult now spends between three and four hours a day on a smartphone, according to data from the analytics firm Data.ai, and a further two on a television or laptop. Novels, by their nature, demand long stretches of uninterrupted attention; phones, by their nature, demand the opposite. A reader who has spent a working day responding to messages in fragments of two minutes has, by evening, a mind shaped to fragments of two minutes. The 400-page novel asks her to change shape, and she is tired.

3

There are, in fairness, less unflattering reasons too. Adult life is **busy** in a way that adolescent life is not. A reader at sixteen has, on a Saturday afternoon, the empty hours that a novel requires. A reader at thirty-six has a job, perhaps a mortgage, often a small child, and a series of obligations — parents to call, a partner to consult, a kitchen to tidy — that adolescence does not impose. The novel is not in competition only with the smartphone. It is in competition with the entire structure of an adult week.

4

What many adults **do** still read is non-fiction, and that, in itself, tells a story. Sales of self-help, business and "productivity" titles have risen steadily over the last fifteen years, even as fiction sales have flattened. The shift is revealing: where the adolescent reader once turned to a novel to **feel** something, the adult reader increasingly turns to a book to **learn** something — to acquire a habit, master a skill, or improve a measurable corner of life. Reading, that is, has become **useful**. And usefulness, as any novelist will tell you, is precisely what fiction has always refused to be.

5

The losses, when one looks closely, are not small. Cognitive scientists at Emory University, scanning the brains of regular novel readers, found increased connectivity in regions associated with **empathy** and the **mental simulation of other lives**. To read a novel is, in a precise and measurable sense, to practise standing inside another person's head — a skill that the rest of adult life rarely demands. There is an emotional loss too. The fiction reader is granted a quiet, sanctioned hour in which to feel things — grief, longing, a strange tenderness for invented people — that the working day does not provide a space for. To stop reading novels is, in a small way, to stop allowing oneself that hour.

6

And there is a slower, harder-to-name loss. Novels teach us to **wait** — for a sentence to land, for a character to change, for a meaning to emerge from a hundred quiet pages. The adult who no longer reads them is, over time, a person whose patience for slowness has thinned. Researchers studying "sustained attention" in adults have found measurable declines in the past fifteen years, in step with the rise of the short-form video. Whether this is cause, effect, or both is still argued. What is not argued is that

the capacity to **dwell** with a long, slow thing — a symphony, a marriage, a book — is a capacity that requires practice, and that, increasingly, adults are out of practice.

7

None of this means the habit cannot be revived. The reader who has not finished a novel in two years can still finish one this month. Librarians and booksellers have long suggested modest, unembarrassed strategies: a short novel rather than a long one, twenty minutes before bed rather than an hour after dinner, a book group whose meeting forces the reading. The novel is not, in the end, a difficult object. It is only a **slow** one — and the question, for the modern adult, is whether one is still willing, every now and again, to be slow.

From Paragraph 1

12. The writer describes the decline in adult reading as “gentle, ordinary, and almost entirely unnoticed.” Explain, in your own words, what this phrase suggests about the way adults stop reading novels. [2]

13. According to Paragraph 1, give **two** pieces of evidence the writer uses to show that the decline in adult fiction reading is real. [2]

From Paragraph 2

14. The writer says that a phone-using mind has been “shaped to fragments of two minutes.” Explain what this means and why it is a problem for novel reading. [2]

From Paragraph 3

15. The writer says the novel “is in competition with the entire structure of an adult week.” What does the writer mean by this? Answer in your own words. [2]

From Paragraph 4

16. Why does the writer place the word **useful** in italics in Paragraph 4? [1]

17. The writer says of usefulness that it is “precisely what fiction has always refused to be.” What does this sentence suggest about the nature of fiction? [2]

From Paragraph 5

18. Explain, in your own words, what cognitive scientists at Emory University discovered about regular novel readers. [2]

19. The writer describes the fiction reader’s hour as “quiet, sanctioned.” What is the effect of the word **sanctioned**? [1]

From Paragraph 6

20. The writer says novels “teach us to wait.” Give **two** details from Paragraph 6 that explain what kind of waiting novels require. [2]

From Paragraph 7

21. The writer ends the article by asking whether the modern adult is “still willing, every now and again, to be slow.” What is the **tone** of this final sentence? **[2]**

22. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **why so many adults stop reading novels**, and **what is lost when they do so**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 2 to 6** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

Many adults stop reading novels because ...

— END OF PAPER —